

Recency Bias

The present is never our goal; the past and present are our means, the future alone is our goal.

—Blaise Pascal (1623 to 1662), French mathematician and philosopher

BIAS DESCRIPTION

Bias Name: Recency bias

Bias Type: Cognitive

Subtype: Information processing

General Description

Recency bias is a cognitive predisposition that causes people to more prominently recall and emphasize recent events and observations than those that occurred in the near or distant past. Suppose, for example, that a cruise passenger peering off the observation deck of a ship spots precisely equal numbers of green boats and blue boats over the duration of the trip. However, if the green boats pass by more frequently toward the end of the cruise, with the passing of blue boats dispersed evenly or concentrated toward the beginning, then recency bias would influence the passenger to recall, following the cruise, that more green than blue boats sailed by.

Technical Description

In order to best understand the technical description of recency bias, it is helpful to examine human memory recall testing, the two main components of which are primacy effect and the recency effect.